

RECLAIMING THE GREEN GOLD

Cannabis at the Crossroads of
Health, Justice, and Sustainable Development



Sunil & Sunny Sweenarain

A GLOBAL HANDBOOK ON CANNABIS ECONOMY • 2026

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Synthesis

This Executive Summary distils the core arguments, analytical framework, and practical instruments developed in Reclaiming the Green Gold: Cannabis at the Crossroads of Health, Justice, and Sustainable Development. It is designed for institutional partners — multilateral agencies, development finance institutions, regional organisations, philanthropic foundations, and policy networks — whose mandates encompass public health, sustainable development, economic governance, and social justice.

The book advances a central conviction: cannabis reform is not a binary legal choice between prohibition and legalisation — it is a governance transition. Outcomes depend less on the legal status adopted than on the quality of institutions, the coherence of policies, and the adaptive learning capacity that states bring to implementation. This reframing has profound implications for how reforms are sequenced, financed, and legitimised in the eyes of the communities they claim to serve.

For developing countries, including Small Island Developing States, the window for deliberate appropriation is open — but it will not remain so indefinitely. Markets are consolidating, standards are being set, and countries that do not invest now in their governance capacities risk being confined to supplying raw biomass while value is captured elsewhere.

We invite your critical engagement, formal endorsement, and active collaboration in translating this work into concrete policy impact — for the benefit of the states and communities that have the most to gain from this historic transition.

2. About the Authors



Dr Soobaschand (Sunil) Sweenarain,

a senior natural resource economist with over three decades of international experience in sustainable development, renewable resource management, economic governance, and policy advisory. Born and raised in Mauritius, he has centred his career primarily on the African continent, where he has led and advised on complex programmes in resource management, regional cooperation, and economic integration.

Rooted in the global sustainability principles driven by the blue-green economy paradigm, Dr Sweenarain has provided expertise in large-scale project design, institutional and human capacity building, and strategic policy advisory services. He has worked extensively with governments, regional organisations, and international partners, contributing to the creation of shared value at national, regional, and global levels. He is the author of numerous technical and strategic reports.

This book reflects Dr Sweenarain's engagement with systems-level analysis, governance design, and development pathways, brought into dialogue with debates on cannabis regulation, bio-economy transitions, and global policy reform. It situates cannabis as a test case for inclusive development, sustainability, and responsible policy transformation across diverse socio-ecological realities.



Sunny Sweenarain,

a medical cannabis specialist, researcher, and international consultant whose work spans the clinical, humanitarian, cultural, and ethical dimensions of medical cannabis. He studied cannabis science in Canada, grounding his practice in evidence-based medical knowledge and exposure to advanced regulatory contexts. His perspective has been shaped by over ten years of work in different developing states worldwide.

Sunny's work centres on patient-oriented medical cannabis applications, clinical interpretation of evidence, and translation of medical knowledge into responsible regulatory and practice frameworks. He is committed to supporting individuals with chronic conditions — integrating clinical understanding with ethical reflection, compassion, and spiritual awareness — while upholding patient dignity, informed choice, and continuity of care. He also engages with the humanitarian and cultural dimensions of cannabis reform, with a focus on preventing addiction and mitigating social harms.

Together, the authors bring an intergenerational and interdisciplinary approach to ***Reclaiming the Green Gold: Cannabis at the Crossroads of Health, Justice, and Sustainable Development***. Their collaboration combines systemic socio-economic and governance analysis with grounded clinical, ethical, and community-based insight — ensuring a nuanced, balanced, and socially responsive understanding of cannabis at this pivotal moment in global policy and practice.

3. The Argument

The central thesis of **Reclaiming the Green Gold** sets out why cannabis reform must be understood as a governance transition rather than a binary legal choice, why the gap between ambition and institutional reality is the defining challenge for developing countries, and why the window for deliberate design will not remain open indefinitely.

3.1 Cannabis at a Crossroads

Cannabis policy is undergoing a profound global transformation. Across Africa, the Caribbean, Latin America, and the Indian Ocean, governments are moving away from prohibition-based approaches toward new regulatory frameworks. This shift is driven by converging forces: advances in scientific understanding, the expansion of legal markets for medicinal cannabis and industrial hemp, and growing recognition of the social and economic costs of punitive enforcement.

Yet this transition is neither linear nor uniform. Countries are legalising faster than they are governing. Licences are issued before laboratories exist. Export frameworks are announced before certification systems are built. The gap between legislative ambition and institutional reality is not a minor detail—it is the defining challenge of this transition.

For low- and middle-income countries (LMICs) and Small Island Developing States (SIDS), the stakes are especially high. Cannabis offers pathways unimaginable a decade ago: revitalising rural economies, anchoring green industrialisation through hemp, enabling small states to compete in high-value medical and wellness markets, and reducing dependence on expensive pharmaceutical imports. Industrial hemp, in particular, aligns with the objectives of sustainable production, climate resilience, and circular economy strategies.

Yet these opportunities carry significant risks. Without deliberate institutional strengthening, the benefits of reform risk capture by well-capitalised outsiders. Local communities and legacy cultivators—those who bore the heaviest costs of prohibition—may remain marginalised. Producer countries may find themselves confined to supplying raw biomass while higher-value functions remain concentrated elsewhere. These are not technical failures. They are distributional injustices.

3.2 The Governance Gap

The problem confronting cannabis reform is not the plant itself. It is governance. The patient work of building institutions, aligning incentives, and designing policies that are honest about what states can deliver is the foundation on which every other ambition depends.

This book is written for those doing that work: policymakers navigating reform with limited resources, development practitioners building capacity where it is scarce, and governance reformers who understand that durable change is built slowly, institutionally, and inclusively. Its central message is captured in a single sentence:

"Legalisation is the easy part. Readiness is the work."

3.3 The Thesis

The book advances a single, overarching argument: cannabis reform is not a binary legal choice. It is a governance transition. Outcomes depend less on whether a country prohibits, decriminalises, or legalises, and more on the institutional capacity, policy coherence, and adaptive learning systems it brings to implementation.

This reframing has profound implications. It shifts attention from legal status to system performance. It demands that reform be sequenced according to institutional readiness, not political expediency. It insists that inclusion and equity are not remedial afterthoughts but foundational conditions of legitimacy and long-term market stability. And it recognises that in a

rapidly evolving sector, policies must be treated as testable hypotheses—monitored, evaluated, and refined over time.

4. The Analytical Framework

The book's analysis rests on three guiding principles and is operationalised through a seven-layer diagnostic model. Together, they provide a structured approach for navigating the complexity of cannabis reform.

4.1 Three Guiding Principles

Differentiation recognises that countries operate under distinct historical, economic, and institutional conditions. Policy models formulated in high-income jurisdictions cannot be transplanted to developing countries and small island states without significant adaptation. What works in Canada will not automatically work in Cameroon. What succeeds in Uruguay requires fundamental rethinking before it can serve Jamaica or Mauritius. Design must be grounded in context-specific realities.

Institutional Readiness holds that reform ambition must align with administrative capacity. Effective cannabis policy depends on the ability to license operators, monitor compliance, ensure product standards, and coordinate across sectors. Experience shows that phased, proportionate approaches succeed, while abrupt overhauls often overwhelm weaker systems. Ambition is not a substitute for capacity—and in this policy domain, the cost of that confusion falls hardest on the most vulnerable.

Adaptive Governance treats policy not as a fixed settlement enacted at a single moment, but as an evolving process of calibration, learning, and recalibration amid persistent uncertainty. No jurisdiction has fully solved cannabis governance. The ones succeeding are those building systems capable of honest self-assessment and continuous adaptation.

4.2 The Cannabis Governance Transition Model

The book's principal intellectual contribution is a diagnostic and strategic framework comprising seven interdependent governance layers. Weakness in any single layer can generate cascading effects that destabilise the entire transition. The model functions as both an assessment tool for evaluating reform readiness and a guide for sequencing governance investments.

1. Evidence Credibility

The capacity to generate, interpret, and apply scientific and administrative data to inform policy and public communication. Without credible evidence, policy becomes vulnerable to ideology and misinformation.

2. Differentiated Public Health

The ability to balance therapeutic access with proportionate safeguards, prevention, and harm reduction calibrated to the actual distribution of risk across populations and products.

3. Value Capture

The institutional and industrial capacity to retain economic benefits domestically through import substitution, export promotion, processing, standards, infrastructure, and value-chain upgrading. Without deliberate investment, producer countries risk falling into the "raw material trap."

4. Justice Repair

Mechanisms for addressing historical harms, including Expungement, community reinvestment, and inclusive pathways for legacy actors. Justice repair transforms reform from a legal adjustment into a visible social settlement.

5. Inclusive Finance

Financial systems that enable participation by smallholders, cooperatives, women, and SMEs rather than concentrating capital among well-resourced firms. This layer determines whether the legal market becomes a broad-based opportunity or a narrow enclave.

6. Digital Trust

Traceability, data governance, and cybersecurity systems that build regulatory credibility without sacrificing sovereignty. Digital trust is the informational backbone of modern cannabis governance.

7. Adaptive Institutional Legitimacy

The capacity to learn, recalibrate, and maintain public trust as conditions evolve. This layer ensures that governance systems remain responsive to emerging evidence and shifting dynamics rather than ossifying over time.

5. The Five-Part Journey: A Synthesis

Beyond its analytical contributions, this book is designed as a toolkit for knowledge sharing, capacity building, and awareness raising. It equips policymakers, development practitioners, and governance reformers with the concepts, evidence, and practical instruments needed to navigate the cannabis transition with clarity, realism, and strategic purpose.

Part I — Cannabis at the Crossroads (Chapters 1–5)

History, Culture, and Legitimacy as Hidden Foundations

The book opens by establishing that cannabis cannot be governed effectively without understanding its deep historical, cultural, and social roots. Cannabis travelled across civilisations for millennia as a medicinal, industrial, and ritual resource, governed not by formal law but by locally embedded knowledge systems that regulated its cultivation, preparation, and use within social norms.

Twentieth-century prohibition did not emerge from scientific consensus. It was shaped by geopolitical interests, colonial governance practices, and racialised narratives that systematically marginalised traditional knowledge. The result was a rupture—the replacement of adaptive, context-specific systems with rigid, centralised control mechanisms that often criminalised the very communities most familiar with the plant.

Key Insight: Legitimacy is foundational. Where formal rules align with cultural norms and lived realities, compliance follows. Where they diverge, informal systems persist and public trust erodes. No legal reform survives long without legitimacy.

Policy Signal: Reform design must begin with historical and cultural literacy. Policymakers should map existing informal systems, engage traditional knowledge holders, and assess the cultural legitimacy of proposed frameworks before legislation is drafted. Ignoring these hidden foundations invites resistance, informality, and enforcement failure.

Part II — Science, Health, and Risk Governance (Chapters 6–8)

From Prohibition to Evidence-Based Policy

This part traces the scientific renaissance that has repositioned cannabis from a stigmatised substance to a legitimate subject of biomedical inquiry. The discovery of the endocannabinoid system—a fundamental physiological regulator—revealed cannabis as deeply embedded in human biology. This was not a minor advance. It was a paradigm shift that forced a re-evaluation of decades of prohibitionist assumptions.

The book examines the therapeutic potential of cannabis-based medicines for chronic pain, epilepsy, chemotherapy-induced nausea, and other conditions, while remaining clear-eyed about the limitations of current evidence and the risks of dependence, mental health impacts, and cognitive impairment.

On public health, the book introduces risk governance as the central framework—an approach that moves beyond the failed binary of prohibition versus unrestricted access. It manages uncertainty through adaptive policy design, balances therapeutic access with proportionate safeguards, and addresses the complex interactions between cannabis, alcohol, tobacco, and opioids.

Key Insight: Scientific evidence is necessary but not sufficient. Effective translation into policy requires coherent regulation, institutional capacity, and sustained attention to equity of access—particularly for populations historically excluded from formal healthcare systems.

Policy Signal: Governments should invest in regulatory science capacity—laboratories, pharmacovigilance systems, and clinical training—before expanding medical access. Public communication must distinguish evidence from ideology, and health frameworks must be designed to reach rural and marginalised populations, not only urban elites.

Part III — Sustainable Cannabis Economy (Chapters 9–11)

Value Chains, Industrial Hemp, and the Raw Material Trap

The economic analysis begins with a sobering observation: in global cannabis value chains, cultivation accounts for only 10–20% of the final product value. The remaining 80–90% is concentrated in processing, extraction, formulation, branding, and retail—functions that remain overwhelmingly located in high-income countries.

This is the "raw material trap." Producer countries with favourable climates and low production costs risk being confined to supplying biomass while the most lucrative segments of the value chain are captured elsewhere. The book demonstrates that this outcome is not determined by geography or climate. It is a product of governance choices—about investment in processing infrastructure, laboratory capacity, standards compliance, and intellectual property regimes.

Industrial hemp receives dedicated attention as a strategic interface between agriculture, industry, and green industrialisation. Its applications span textiles, construction materials, bioplastics, food, and nutraceuticals, offering pathways for rural economic diversification that align with sustainability and circular economy objectives.

Key Insight: Economic potential is contingent on governance. Countries that supply raw material without the infrastructure to process, certify, or brand risk permanent subordination in global value chains—not because of any natural disadvantage, but because of governance gaps that are entirely addressable.

Policy Signal: Trade and industrial policy must be integrated into cannabis reform from the outset. Governments should incentivise domestic processing, invest in certification infrastructure, and negotiate market access collectively through regional blocs. Cultivation licences alone will not deliver development; beneficiation strategies will.

Part IV — Governance and Development Pathways (Chapters 12–17)

Regulatory Design, Justice, Institutions, and Finance

This part forms the operational core of the book. It moves from analysis to architecture, examining how regulatory systems can be designed, how institutions can be built, and how justice and inclusion can be embedded in the DNA of reform.

The book compares medical, adult-use, state-controlled, and hybrid regulatory models across jurisdictions, drawing lessons from Canada, Uruguay, Germany, Jamaica, Lesotho, Morocco,

Thailand, and others. It demonstrates that models are not fully transferable; each must be adapted to local institutional capacity and political economy.

A full chapter is devoted to the international treaty system—the 1961, 1971, and 1988 conventions—and the legal flexibilities that states increasingly rely upon. The book argues that the treaty architecture is no longer a monolithic barrier but a structured and contested legal environment within which states can exercise strategic autonomy.

On justice, the book is unequivocal. Communities that bore prohibition's heaviest costs—smallholders criminalised for subsistence, Indigenous practitioners whose knowledge was appropriated, populations over-policed while others operated freely—are owed more than belated inclusion. They are owed recognition, repair, and genuine participation in governing the systems now built in their name. Reforms that fail here reproduce the asymmetries they claim to leave behind.

The financing chapter analyses investment models, fiscal regimes, and the specific constraints facing LMICs, where conventional banks remain reluctant to engage with the sector and domestic enterprises struggle to access the capital needed for compliance and upgrading.

Key Insight: Durable reform depends on coherent governance architectures that align regulatory design, institutional capacity, inclusive participation, and sustainable finance. Weakness in any one of these dimensions can destabilise the entire transition.

Policy Signal: Governments should sequence reform around institutional readiness, not political pressure. A phased approach—beginning with foundational licensing and public education, adding product standards and laboratory capacity, then expanding market access—is more durable than a rushed comprehensive framework. Justice measures, including expungement and legacy grower pathways, must be embedded at the design stage, not retrofitted later.

Part V — System Design and Futures (Chapters 18–20)

Implementation, Learning, and Digital Sovereignty

The final part confronts the reality that many reform processes fail not because their objectives are incoherent, but because they underestimate the difficulty of moving from policy declaration to operational reality. Implementation is where legal reform becomes legitimate in practice—or fails to do so.

The book advocates phased, sequenced approaches that match ambition to institutional capability. Uruguay's four-year journey from legislation to pharmacy dispensing is presented as a model of deliberate pacing. Pilots, regulatory sandboxes, and graduated compliance pathways are examined as instruments for learning before scaling.

On evidence and learning, the book argues that cannabis governance must be built around adaptive systems that treat policies as testable hypotheses. Monitoring, evaluation, and feedback loops are not bureaucratic overhead. They are essential infrastructure for detecting unintended consequences and refining rules before problems become entrenched.

The final chapter looks to the future, examining digital compliance, AI ethics, and the emerging risks of algorithmic bias and cyber-fragility. For developing countries, it introduces the concept of digital sovereignty—the imperative to avoid a new form of dependency where foreign-hosted traceability platforms harvest sensitive commercial intelligence and become chokepoints for market access. Regional cooperation is presented as the most viable pathway to collective digital statecraft.

Key Insight: Reform becomes durable not when it is declared complete, but when it can be measured, questioned, and improved over time. Adaptive governance is not a sign of indecision but of institutional maturity.

Policy Signal: Every cannabis law should include a mandatory review clause and a commitment to public reporting against predefined indicators. Governments should invest in data systems from day one—not as a later upgrade. Digital infrastructure choices, particularly for traceability, must be assessed for sovereignty implications, with regional open-source platforms preferred over proprietary foreign systems that create new forms of dependency.

6. Main Takeaways

Several cross-cutting insights emerge across the five parts of the book. These are not chapter summaries. They are the book's enduring messages for policy and practice.

Legalisation is the easy part. Readiness is the work. Changing a law is a political act. Building the institutions, standards, laboratories, licensing systems, and learning mechanisms that make a law function is a governance project. The book's primary purpose is to equip governments for that second, harder task.

Cannabis is a governance issue, not a legal one. The binary debate between prohibition and legalisation obscures more than it reveals. The real question is how cannabis systems are designed, who they include, and whether they can learn and adapt. The quality of governance—not the legal label—determines outcomes.

Legitimacy is the hidden infrastructure of reform. Policies that ignore history, culture, and justice may appear efficient on paper but fail in practice. Trust, once fractured by decades of selective criminalisation, cannot be restored by legislative repeal alone. It must be rebuilt through visible fairness, inclusive participation, and tangible repair.

Economic potential is real but contingent. Cannabis can support diversification, green industrialisation, and rural livelihoods. But without deliberate strategies for value addition, standards compliance, and domestic processing, producer countries risk the raw material trap—supplying biomass while value is captured elsewhere. This outcome is not inevitable. It is a product of governance choices.

The window for deliberate design is open but closing. Global markets are consolidating. Early movers are establishing buyer relationships and regulatory recognition. The countries that invest now in the seven governance layers—before market structures harden and regulatory expectations rise—will shape their own futures. Those who delay will find their options constrained by rules they had no hand in writing.

7. Objectives and Expected Outcomes

This book is not a conventional academic monograph or a compilation of policy briefs. It has been conceived and executed as a Global Handbook on the Cannabis Economy—a comprehensive, integrated, and practical resource designed to produce measurable outcomes for its users.

7.1 Main Objectives

1. Reframe the Global Debate

To shift cannabis discourse from a binary legal question to a governance and development challenge, establishing a new vocabulary and analytical standard for policymakers, international organisations, and development partners.

2. Provide a Diagnostic and Strategic Framework

To equip governments with the Cannabis Governance Transition Model—a seven-layer architecture that enables systematic assessment of national readiness and identification of critical gaps before reform is launched or scaled.

3. Build Institutional Capacity

To serve as a knowledge-sharing and capacity-building toolkit that strengthens the ability of public institutions—ministries of health, agriculture, justice, trade, and finance—to design, implement, and adapt cannabis policies coherently.

4. Embed Justice and Inclusion

To ensure that equity, repair, and inclusive participation are treated not as peripheral aspirations but as core design principles, grounded in the recognition of prohibition's unequal harms and the rights of legacy actors and traditional knowledge holders.

5. Support Strategic Economic Positioning

To provide developing countries, including the Small Island States with the economic literacy—on value chains, market structures, compliance costs, and trade dynamics—needed to move beyond raw material supply toward higher-value segments of the global cannabis economy.

6. Foster Regional and International Cooperation

To make the case for shared laboratories, harmonised standards, pooled training, and collective negotiation as pathways for smaller economies to overcome structural smallness and build coordinated capability.

7. Promote Adaptive and Evidence-Based Governance

To institutionalise the principle that cannabis policy must be treated as a learning system—monitored, evaluated, and refined—rather than a static legal settlement.

7.2 Expected Results

The book is designed to deliver the following tangible results for its target audiences:

(a) Policymakers and Regulators

Clear understanding of why legal reform without institutional readiness is insufficient.

Practical framework—the seven-layer model—for diagnosing national preparedness.

Detailed comparative analysis of regulatory models, with lessons adaptable to local contexts.

Sequenced approach to reform: where to start, what to prioritise, and how to phase implementation.

(b) Development Practitioners and Technical Assistance Providers

Comprehensive knowledge base that can inform programme design, capacity-building missions, and policy advisory services.

National Cannabis Economy Readiness Toolkit—a guided self-assessment instrument covering 13 dimensions across three clusters—can be deployed in client countries.

Evidence and arguments to support the integration of cannabis governance into broader development strategies, including SDG alignment and green economy transitions.

(c) International and Regional Organisations

Robust analytical foundation for developing guidance, standards, and model frameworks adapted to developing countries and small island states' realities.

Compelling case for regional cooperation on shared laboratories, harmonised certification, and pooled market intelligence.

A forward agenda identifying priority areas for research, investment, and institutional strengthening.

(d) Academia and Research Institutions

Interdisciplinary synthesis spanning history, ethnography, pharmacology, economics, law, and governance.

A rich set of hypotheses and research questions for further investigation.

- Detailed bibliographic resources and comparative data.

For Civil Society and Advocacy Groups

Evidence-based arguments to support advocacy for just, inclusive, and development-oriented cannabis reform.

Tools for holding governments accountable for the equity and public health commitments embedded in reform legislation.

For Investors and Private Sector Actors

A realistic assessment of market opportunities, risks, and compliance requirements across segments.

An understanding of the governance conditions that distinguish viable investment environments from fragile ones.

7.3 A Unique Global Handbook

Several features distinguish this book from existing publications on cannabis policy:

First, its comprehensive scope. No other single work integrates historical analysis, cultural ethnography, pharmacology, clinical practice, public health, economics, regulatory design, international law, justice theory, institutional governance, development pathways, sustainable finance, implementation science, and digital futures within a single analytical framework.

Second, its perspective. The book is written from and for the Global South. While it engages extensively with experiences from high-income countries, its primary orientation is toward the challenges and opportunities facing LMICs and SIDS. This perspective is rare in a field dominated by Northern voices and Northern case studies.

Third, its practical utility. The book is not content to analyse. It provides instruments for action. The three annexes—a global market snapshot, a comparative analysis of governance models, and a national readiness toolkit—translate analysis into application. They enable governments and development partners to move from understanding to implementation.

Fourth, its ethical grounding. The book treats justice not as a concession to political correctness but as a structural requirement for durable reform. Its insistence on repair, recognition, and inclusive participation is grounded in a rigorous analysis of prohibition's unequal burdens and the risks that legal markets will reproduce them.

Fifth, its adaptive posture. The book does not offer a single blueprint. It provides a framework for thinking, diagnosing, sequencing, and learning. It recognises that in a rapidly evolving sector, the most valuable capacity is not the right answer, but the right process for finding and revising answers over time.

8. The Practical Toolkit

The book is complemented by three substantive annexes designed to move the analysis from argument to application. Together, they form a practical toolkit for governments, development partners, and stakeholders.

Annexe 1: A Snapshot of the Global Cannabis Economy

This annexe brings together key facts, figures, and market signals on demand, production, value chains, and growth potential. It translates the book's economic analysis into accessible visual summaries, covering market size (USD 35–40 billion in 2024, projected to exceed USD 100 billion by 2030), trade flows, employment, taxation, and the differentiated growth trajectories of medical cannabis, adult-use markets, and industrial hemp.

The annexe also presents three growth scenarios—conservative, base case, and accelerated—as a strategic planning tool for policymakers and investors. It highlights where LMICs and SIDS can realistically position themselves, from medical supply and agro-processing to testing services and niche exports.

Annexe 2: Comparative Analysis of Cannabis Governance Models

This annexe examines how countries have actually designed and operated their regulatory systems. It maps the diversity of approaches from prohibition to medical access to commercial legalisation, drawing out the lessons each model offers to jurisdictions at earlier stages of reform.

Eight country archetypes are presented, including public-health state models (Uruguay), federal commercial models (Canada), fragmented subnational models (United States), cultural-rights models (Jamaica), judiciary-led models (South Africa), and export-led development models (Lesotho, Morocco, Colombia). The annexe also provides a governance readiness diagnostic, helping countries identify which model fits their level of institutional capacity.

Annexe 3: National Cannabis Economy Readiness Toolkit (NCE-SAF)

This toolkit is the book's most directly operational instrument. It provides a guided self-assessment framework across 13 readiness dimensions, grouped into three clusters:

Cluster A — Governance Foundations: National vision and strategy; legal and regulatory framework; institutional and governance capacity.

Cluster B — People, Economy, and Environment: Public health and human rights; economic and market development; agriculture, environment, and sustainability; social equity and community participation.

Cluster C — Enablers, Accountability, and Alignment: Knowledge, data, and digital systems; cultural and spiritual dimensions; monitoring, evaluation, and learning; international and regional alignment; community participation and local governance; SDG and green economy alignment.

Each dimension is assessed using diagnostic questions, evidence prompts, and a traffic-light scoring system (Green/Orange/Red). The toolkit then guides users through consolidated scoring, holistic interpretation, and the development of a priority action matrix with lead agencies, timelines, and success indicators. It is designed for use by multi-ministry teams and can be completed in a facilitated workshop or through a structured inter-ministerial process.

9. A Call to Action

This book is not an academic exercise. It is a strategic instrument. Its value will be measured by the extent to which it informs policy, builds capacity, and shapes the governance architectures through which cannabis reform delivers public value. We invite your institution to join us in this effort.

9.1 Why This Book Matters for Your Institution

The governance challenges analysed in this book intersect directly with the mandates of multilateral organisations, development agencies, regional bodies, and philanthropic foundations:

a) United Nations Agencies (UNDP, UNCTAD, UNODC, WHO): The book provides an integrated framework for aligning cannabis policy with the Sustainable Development Goals,

offering instruments for SDG-linked monitoring, institutional capacity assessment, and development-oriented regulatory design.

b) African Union and African regional economic communities: The book positions cannabis within Agenda 2063 and continental strategies for pharmaceutical sovereignty, agro-industrialisation, and intra-African trade. The readiness toolkit can support member states in assessing preparedness and sequencing reform.

c) CARICOM and SIDS-focused organisations: The book addresses the specific constraints of small economies—limited scale, high logistics costs, climate vulnerability—and demonstrates how niche strategies, regional cooperation, and pooled infrastructure can transform structural smallness into coordinated capability.

d) Development finance institutions (AfDB, World Bank, IFC): The book's analysis of investment models, blended finance, fiscal regimes, and SME access to capital provides a foundation for designing financial instruments that support inclusive cannabis sector development.

e) Philanthropic foundations: The book's emphasis on justice, equity, and the inclusion of historically marginalised communities aligns with the social justice mandates of foundations working at the intersection of health, human rights, and economic opportunity.

9.2 Specific Opportunities for Collaboration

We invite your institution to consider the following forms of partnership:

1. Endorsement

A formal endorsement from your institution would amplify the book's credibility and signal to member states and partners that cannabis governance is a legitimate and urgent development priority. This could take the form of a foreword, a cover endorsement, or an institutional statement of support.

2. Translation and Dissemination

The book is currently available in English, and we are seeking partners to support its translation into French and other languages in order to broaden its accessibility to policymakers and stakeholders worldwide. Support for regional launch events, policy dialogues, and digital dissemination initiatives would further strengthen the book's global reach and impact.

3. Integration into Technical Assistance Programmes

The National Cannabis Economy Readiness Toolkit (NCE-SAF) is designed for deployment in technical assistance missions. We invite partnerships to pilot the toolkit in interested member states, train multi-ministry teams in its application, and develop case studies that can inform regional learning.

4. Regional and Thematic Research Partnerships

The book identifies numerous areas where further research is needed—from climate-resilient hemp cultivation to the impact of digital compliance systems on smallholder participation. We welcome partnerships with research institutions and policy networks to deepen the evidence base.

5. Policy Dialogues and Capacity-Building Workshops

We propose a series of regional policy dialogues—in Africa, the Caribbean, and the Indian Ocean—to bring together policymakers, regulators, and stakeholders around the book's framework. These dialogues would serve as platforms for peer learning, South-South cooperation, and the development of context-specific reform pathways.

9.3 Call for Action

The window for deliberate design is open but closing. The countries and institutions that act now—before markets consolidate, before regulatory expectations harden, before the political moment passes—will shape the cannabis governance landscape for decades to come.

We invite you to join us in this work. Your endorsement, partnership, and engagement can help ensure that cannabis reform delivers not merely legal markets, but legitimate, inclusive, and adaptive systems of governance that serve the public interest.

10. Concluding Remarks

Reclaiming the Green Gold is not solely a book about cannabis. It is about something bigger: the capacity of states to govern complex transitions amid uncertainty. The lessons learned here—about sequencing reform under institutional constraints, retaining value in global markets, repairing historical harm, and building adaptive systems—are transferable to climate adaptation, digital transformation, and the other profound challenges that define this era of governance.

The cannabis future will not be inherited passively. It will be woven through deliberate choices about institutions, inclusion, evidence, and trust.

Sunil & Sunny Sweenarain

Mauritius, May 2026